Edexcel GCSE Geography B (1GB0) — Component 3: People and Environment Issues · Section D: Making Geographical Decisions

3.4 Making Geographical Decisions

1. The Decision-Making Exercise

Component 3 (**People and Environment Issues — Making Geographical Decisions**) is a 1 hour 30 minute exam worth **64 marks** (including 4 marks for SPaG). It is based on a **resource booklet given out in the exam** — there is no pre-release. The booklet focuses on a particular place and issue linked to Topics 7–9.

Section	Content
Section A	People and the Biosphere — questions using the resources and your knowledge of Topic 7
Section B	Forests under Threat — Topic 8
Section C	Consuming Energy Resources — Topic 9
Section D	The decision — choose one of three options and justify it (12 marks plus 4 SPaG)

2. How to Approach the Resource Booklet

1. Spend a few minutes skimming the whole booklet before answering — understand the place, the issue and the options.
2. Annotate figures as you go: what does each show, and does it support or oppose any option?
3. Identify the **stakeholders** and their likely views.
4. Use both the resources *and* your own knowledge of the biosphere, forests and energy.

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3. Making and Justifying the Decision

- Choose **one** option and state it clearly at the start.
- Justify it using evidence from several figures — quote data and refer to figure numbers.
- Consider **economic, social and environmental** impacts, in the **short and long term**, and for **different stakeholders**.
- Explain why you rejected the other options.
- Acknowledge the weaknesses of your chosen option and suggest how they could be reduced.
- Link to **sustainability** — does the option meet present needs without harming future generations?

4. Useful Frameworks

Framework	Use
SEE / SEEP	Social, Economic, Environmental (and Political) impacts
Futures wheel	Map out the knock-on effects of a decision
Cost–benefit analysis	Weigh up gains and losses of each option
Stakeholder conflict matrix	Show which groups agree and disagree

Exam Tip: The highest marks go to answers that are *balanced but decisive*: they recognise that every option has drawbacks, but still reach a clear, well-supported judgement. Leave time to check spelling, punctuation and grammar — 4 SPaG marks are available on the final question.

5. Geographical Skills for Component 3

- Interpreting maps, graphs, tables, photographs and newspaper extracts.
- Calculating percentages, percentage change, means and ranges.
- Recognising bias in sources — who wrote it, and why?
- Comparing data from different places and times.

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